test for Indian foreign policy-makers to decide whether to accept occupation of its neighboring country by a friendly force or not. The debate between partisans and conciliators, the chapter shows, had begun to brew long before the Soviet Union's retreat from Afghanistan in 1989 and its subsequent disintegration in 1991.

The second part of the book, debating containment, delves into events that led India to more or less embrace the proxy-war format vis-à-vis Pakistan in Afghanistan during the 1990s and early years of the twenty-first century. The fourth chapter, 'The Taliban Dilemma', specifically details how the partisans and conciliators collided head-on in early 1990s when Najibullah was ousted in a coup. The chapter also highlights debates that took place in India when Kabul fell to the Taliban in September 1996, and how India's policy evolved in accordance with regional and international developments. The newly created Central Asian Republics (CARs) in the early 1990s had unleashed a scramble for power by many regional stakeholders, of which India was one. These changing geopolitical realities, and the role of the UN in calibrating a peace process in Afghanistan played an important role in impacting India's operational logic towards Afghanistan during the Taliban era. By late 1990s events such as the hijacking of the Indian Airlines flight IC-814 by Pakistan-based militants (and its landing in Taliban-controlled Kandahar), and the destruction of the Bamiyan Buddhas in 2001 crystalised India's aversion of the Taliban. Complementing these debates on how to deal with the Taliban were India's relations with the anti-Taliban United Front (UF). The fifth chapter, 'Friends from North, Foes from South', analyses the nature and extent of New Delhi's links with the UF. This relationship, despite being an open secret, has not been delved into. This chapter argues that unlike popular perception of the UF's dependence on support from New Delhi to continue its fight against the Taliban, it was India that was strategically dependent on the UF to secure its interests in Afghanistan. The sixth chapter, 'War and Terror', then shows how the strength of India's relations with the UF got tested at the 2001 Bonn conference that pushed Hamid Karzai to power in Kabul.

The third part of the book, debating engagement, consists of three chapters and analyses India's approach towards Afghanistan after 9/11. The seventh